LISTEN · LEARN · SPEAK

Why We Laugh (It's Not Because of Jokes)

What really makes us laugh, what laughing does to your body, how to spot sarcasm – lots of funny English – and the story of a very confident pigeon.



Name: _____

Date: _____

My score: _____ / 100 ⭐

★ How to use this worksheet

1 · Before you listen 🧠
Do the warm-up and learn the key words. Questions with 🧠 can be answered before listening.

2 · While you listen 🎧
Answer the 🎧 questions. The ⏱ times show where to find each part of the video.

3 · After you listen 💬
Spot the sarcasm, solve the word search and share your funniest English moment!

0 Warm-up: My laugh check

fun · no points

Think about yesterday. Where did you laugh the most? Tick all that are true.

- ☐ 👫 with friends
- ☐ 🏠 with my family
- ☐ 📱 watching videos alone
- ☐ 💼 at work or school
- ☐ 💬 reading messages
- ☐ 🙈 at my own mistake

Guess! A scientist listened to people laughing in cafés and shops. How many laughs came after something like a **joke**?

(a) about 70% (b) about 40% (c) only 10–20%

🎧 **Check your guess at ⏱ 0:05**

Jack: "With my brother, we laugh at almost nothing. A stranger would think we were mad!" 😆



💬 Let's talk

Say your answers out loud – or write them in your notebook.

1. Who makes you laugh the most? Why?

2. What was the last thing that made you really laugh?

3. Do you understand jokes in English? What's hard about them?

4. Have you ever made a funny mistake in another language?

1 Key words

vocabulary · 10 points

Match each word or phrase (1–10) to its meaning (a–j). Write the letter in the box. 🧠 Check in the Word Tour at ⏱️ 14:16

- ☐ **1.** contagious
- ☐ **2.** to giggle
- ☐ **3.** to chuckle
- ☐ **4.** to be in stitches
- ☐ **5.** to keep a straight face
- ☐ **6.** hilarious
- ☐ **7.** to burst out laughing
- ☐ **8.** to pull someone's leg
- ☐ **9.** to get (a joke)
- ☐ **10.** a sitcom

a) to understand a joke
b) spreading easily from one person to another
c) to laugh quietly, usually to yourself
d) extremely funny
e) to suddenly start laughing loudly
f) to joke by telling someone something that isn't true
g) to laugh in a light, high, often silly way
h) a funny TV series about the same characters in everyday situations
i) to laugh so much that it almost hurts
j) to not laugh or smile, even when something is funny



Pronunciation corner 🔊 hi-**LAIR**-ee-us · con-**TA**-gious · **SAR**-casm · **SIT**-com · **CHUCK**-le. And the "gh" in **laugh** sounds like **f**: /lɑːf/. Say it out loud: *"That was absolutely hilarious!"*

2 First listen: the big idea

listening · 2 points

Watch the whole episode once without stopping. Which sentence is the **main message**? 🎧

- (a) Most laughter comes after jokes, so you need to learn clever jokes in English.
- (b) Most laughter isn't about jokes – it's a friendly signal we share with other people.
- (c) Laughing is bad for your body, so it's better to keep a straight face.



Jack's tip: First listen = the **big picture**. Don't stop the video and don't worry about every word. Second listen = the **details**. That's when you answer the 🎧 questions.

🔮 **Predict before you listen!** (no points) Seven of these words are in the episode. One is **not**. Circle the one you think you **won't** hear – then check while you listen.

shopping centres · **cuff** · **sitcom** · **waiter** · **banana** · **intern** · **sock** · **pigeon**

3 Know it or hear it? quiz + listening 10 points

Circle a, b or c. Questions 🧠 1–5: you can probably answer them **before** you listen. Questions 🎧 6–10: listen to find the answer.



🧠 YOU MIGHT ALREADY KNOW

1. "Hilarious" means…

(a) a little bit funny
(b) extremely funny
(c) not funny at all

🧠 Look at Exercise 1

2. You didn't understand a joke. The most natural reply is…

(a) "Sorry, I didn't get it."
(b) "Sorry, I didn't take it."
(c) "Sorry, I don't joke."

🧠 Look at Exercise 1

3. "The party was really _____ – we danced all night!"

(a) funny
(b) fun
(c) funnily

🧠 Tricky – think about it!

4. Something "contagious"…

(a) spreads from person to person
(b) is very loud
(c) happens very rarely

🧠 Look at Exercise 1

5. "Please don't laugh _____ me!"

(a) to
(b) on
(c) at

🧠 Grammar you know

🎉 **How many did you know?**
Now press play and test your ears!

🎧 LISTEN AND FIND OUT

6. Which sentence made people laugh in Provine's research?

(a) "See you later."
(b) "Here's a funny joke."
(c) "Please laugh now."

🎧 ⏱️ 0:05

7. In a conversation, who laughs more?

(a) the person who is listening
(b) the person who is speaking
(c) they both laugh the same

🎧 ⏱️ 2:17

8. Lucy wanted fish in a French restaurant. What did she ask for?

(a) chicken
(b) the bill
(c) poison

🎧 ⏱️ 6:57

9. What was the ringtone on the boss's phone?

(a) a dog barking
(b) a duck quacking
(c) a bell ringing

🎧 ⏱️ 11:59

10. Diego said the pigeon had a question about…

(a) the past simple
(b) the weather
(c) the present perfect

🎧 ⏱️ 18:47

🧩 **Fun fact:** We usually laugh at the **end** of a phrase – like a full stop or a comma. Laughter fits into language!

4 True or false? listening 6 points

Listen and circle **T** (true) or **F** (false). The ⏱️ times help you find the answer.

1	Provine and his students listened to people laughing in shopping centres and cafés.	T	F	⏱️ 0:05
2	We usually laugh in the middle of a sentence.	T	F	⏱️ 2:17
3	When you hear someone laughing, it's hard not to laugh too.	T	F	⏱️ 4:25
4	Deep laughing is hard physical work for your body.	T	F	⏱️ 5:32
5	In Robin Dunbar's study, people watched the comedy videos alone.	T	F	⏱️ 5:32
6	After Lucy's mistake, the French waiter was unfriendly all evening.	T	F	⏱️ 6:57

5 Laughter by numbers 🔍 listening 5 points



Match each number (a–e) to the right fact. Write the letter in the box. ⏱️ 0:05 · 2:17 · 4:25 · 5:32

a) 10–20% **b) about 50%** **c) 30 times** **d) 15 minutes** **e) 10%**

1. how much more the **speaker** laughs than the listener ☐

2. how much your pain threshold went up after laughing ☐

3. how many laughs came after something like a joke ☐

4. how long people watched comedy together in Dunbar's study ☐

5. how much more people laughed with others than alone ☐

6 Funny mix-ups 🐟 new! pronunciation 4 points



Lucy asked for **poison** instead of **poisson** (fish)! Circle the word each speaker **meant**. Then say both words out loud – can you hear the difference?

1. "Can I have the _____ soup, please?" **kitchen** **chicken**

2. "I'm so _____ – I haven't eaten all day!" **hungry** **angry**

3. "For _____, I'd like chocolate cake." **desert** **dessert**

4. "Can I borrow a _____? I need to write this down." **pan** **pen**

🧪 **Laughter glue:** real, deep laughing is hard work for your body. It seems to release **endorphins** – natural chemicals in your brain that help you feel good and reduce pain. And they may help people feel **closer** to each other!

7 "You had to be there!" listening 10 points



Two friends talk about something that happened at work. Listen at ⏱️ 11:59 and write **one word** in each gap (1–8). Then answer A and B. The breakdown at ⏱️ 13:18 can help.



LUCY
You look very 1 _____ today. What happened?

JACK
Oh, I have to tell you. Yesterday, in our big meeting, my boss was giving a really serious presentation about money.





LUCY
Okay...

JACK
And halfway through, his phone started ringing really loudly. And his ringtone was a 2 _____. Just a duck, quacking.





LUCY
No 3 _____! What did everyone do?

JACK
At first, total silence. Everyone was trying to keep a straight 4 _____. And then the new intern started 5 _____, and that was it. The whole room burst out laughing.





LUCY
Even your boss?

JACK
He was in 6 _____. He couldn't finish his sentence for about two minutes. Honestly, I haven't laughed like that for ages.





LUCY
That's hilarious. I'm 7 _____ up just imagining it.

JACK
You had to be 8 _____, really. But it was the best meeting we've ever had.



A. What do we say when a story is **funnier in real life** than when you tell it?

_____

B. Find the phrase that means **"suddenly started laughing loudly"**:

_____

🎭 **Say it out loud!** Play both parts – then tell the story again with a funny moment from **your** life.

8 The laugh-o-meter 📈

new! word scale · 6 points

How big is each laugh? Put the six expressions (a–f) in the right part of the meter. ⏱️ 14:16



a) to chuckle · **b) to be in stitches** · **c) to burst out laughing** · **d) to giggle** · **e) to nearly die laughing** · **f) to crack up**

🤭 QUIET	😆 SUDDEN & LOUD	🤣 CAN'T STOP!
a small, soft laugh – maybe one you're trying to hide	you start laughing a lot, all at once	you laugh so much that it hurts
☐ ☐	☐ ☐	☐ ☐



Lucy's tip: Giggle is often a silly or nervous laugh – children giggle. **Chuckle** is warm and quiet – you chuckle when you read a funny message. Using the right word makes your stories come alive!

9 Sincere or sarcastic? 😏

new! listening for meaning · 6 points



Read the situation. Does the person **mean it** (sincere), or mean the **opposite** (sarcastic)? Tick one. ⏱️ 10:31

1. 🌧️ It's pouring with rain. Your friend says:
"Lovely weather today!"
☐ 😊 SINCERE ☐ 😏 SARCASTIC

2. 🚗 Your friend has just passed her driving test. You say:
"Well done! I'm so proud of you!"
☐ 😊 SINCERE ☐ 😏 SARCASTIC

3. 🥪 Your colleague drops his whole lunch on the floor. He says:
"Well, that went well."
☐ 😊 SINCERE ☐ 😏 SARCASTIC

4. 📰 Your colleague is relaxing with a coffee and a newspaper. Someone says:
"Wow, you look really busy!"
☐ 😊 SINCERE ☐ 😏 SARCASTIC

5. ☀️ The sun is shining and it's warm. Your neighbour says:
"Lovely weather today!"
☐ 😊 SINCERE ☐ 😏 SARCASTIC

6. 🍝 Your friend cooks you a delicious dinner. You say:
"This is amazing – thank you!"
☐ 😊 SINCERE ☐ 😏 SARCASTIC



How to spot sarcasm: the words don't match the situation · the voice is slower, flatter or a bit exaggerated · there's often a tiny smile or a pause. Not sure? Just smile and say, *"You're joking, right?"* And be careful with sarcasm in **messages** – nobody can hear your voice!

10 fun · funny · laugh at · laugh with

common mistakes · 6 points



Complete each sentence with **fun**, **funny**, **at** or **with**.

fun 🎉 = enjoyable, a good time
"The party was really fun." · "We had lots of fun."

funny 😂 = it makes you laugh (or: strange)
"He's so funny!" · "This milk smells funny."

1. The party was really _____ – we danced all night.
2. My brother is so _____ – he always makes me laugh.
3. This soup tastes a bit _____. Is it OK?
4. We had lots of _____ at the beach yesterday.
5. It isn't kind to laugh _____ people when they make mistakes.
6. Don't worry – we're laughing _____ you, not at you!

11 Say it better

common mistakes · 10 points

These sentences sound unnatural. Write a more natural version (2 points each). ⏱️ 16:48

😐 1. "Are you making joke?" 😊 _____

😐 2. "I died from laughing." 😊 _____

😐 3. "I didn't understand the joke." 😊 _____

😐 4. "It was very very funny." 😊 _____

😐 5. "Are you serious? I don't believe!" (your friend tells you something hard to believe) 😊 _____



Remember: if you laugh **at** someone, you make fun of them – that can hurt. If you laugh **with** someone, you laugh together and everyone enjoys it. Small word, big difference! 💜



Share it with us! Tell us in the comments about your **funniest moment while learning English** – a funny mistake, like Lucy's French poison. We'll read them all (and probably laugh – **with** you!). 💜

12 Clue word search + secret message

puzzle · 11 points



Step 1: Complete each clue – the first letter and the number of letters are given (1 point each). **Step 2:** Find the 11 words in the grid. They go → ↓ ↘ or ↗ and never cross each other.

1. Laughter is **c**_____: it spreads from person to person.
2. Extremely funny: "That video was **h**_____!"
3. Jack's boss was in **s**_____ – he couldn't stop laughing.
4. Older people often **c**_____ – a quiet, warm laugh.
5. "Lovely weather!" when it's pouring with rain is **s**_____.
6. Children often **g**_____ at the back of the classroom.
7. A funny TV series about the same people at home or at work: a **s**_____.
8. A **p**_____ flew into Lucy's classroom and walked across her papers.
9. In France, Lucy asked the waiter for **p**_____ instead of fish!
10. In the meeting, the boss's phone **r**_____ played really loudly.
11. Quack, quack! The ringtone was a **d**___.

Y	R	P	C	H	U	C	K	L	E	S
P	I	O	S	I	T	C	O	M	U	O
I	N	I	U	D	O	N	T	O	H	N
G	G	S	E	E	D	M	I	T	I	S
E	T	O	O	B	S	G	E	A	L	T
O	O	N	C	A	A	O	M	E	A	I
N	N	E	C	T	D	I	L	A	R	T
N	E	R	N	Y	D	G	O	U	I	C
J	A	O	U	S	G	U	T	N	O	H
S	C	E	E	I	D	T	C	O	U	E
B	E	T	G	H	E	R	E	K	S	S

🤫 **Step 3 – the secret message** (no points) Cross out the 11 words. Then write the letters that are left, row by row, from left to right. It's Jack's advice from the end of the episode!

_____ _____'__ _____ ___ ___ __ _____. _____

_____ _____ ___ ___ _____.



13 The pigeon story 🐦

listening · 6 points

Listen at ⏱️ 18:47. Put the events in the right order. Write 1–6 in the boxes.

- ☐ 🐦 A pigeon flew in and walked across Lucy's papers.
- ☐ 💌 On the last day, Diego gave Lucy a card with a pigeon wearing glasses.
- ☐ 🤫 Lucy had a quiet evening class, and Diego was very shy.
- ☐ 😂 The whole class exploded with laughter.
- ☐ 🪟 One warm evening, Lucy opened the window.
- ☐ 💬 Diego said, "I think he has a question about the present perfect."

Think about it 💭 (no points) How was the class different after that night? Why?



14 Your turn

writing · 8 points

2 points for each good sentence.

A. My funniest English moment 😂

Write two sentences. Use **burst out laughing**, **in stitches** or **couldn't keep a straight face**. *e.g. "I asked for a 'pan' instead of a 'pen', and the whole class burst out laughing."*

B. One situation, two replies 😊 😏

Your friend arrives **one hour late**. Write one **sincere** reply and one friendly **sarcastic** reply. *e.g. "Oh, you're right on time!"*

📓 My laugh log

your 7-day mission

Jack's challenge: notice when you laugh – and why. Was it a **joke** 🃏 or just a **moment** ✨?

Day	What made me laugh?	Who was I with?	Joke 🃏 or moment ✨?
1			🃏 · ✨
2			🃏 · ✨
3			🃏 · ✨
4			🃏 · ✨
5			🃏 · ✨
6			🃏 · ✨
7			🃏 · ✨

✂️ Cut out and keep in your pocket

🙈 DIDN'T GET IT
Sorry, I didn't get that.
Can you explain?
You're joking, right?

😂 REACT
That's hilarious!
I'm cracking up!
We were in stitches.

😏 IRONY
"Lovely weather!" (in the rain)
"Well, that went well."

💜 BE KIND
I was only joking!
Laugh **with** people, not **at** them.

Can you do it now?

I can…	Not yet	Almost	Yes!
explain why most laughter isn't about jokes.	😟	🙂	😄
describe different laughs: giggle, chuckle, in stitches…	😟	🙂	😄
tell when someone is being sarcastic.	😟	🙂	😄
say politely when I didn't get a joke.	😟	🙂	😄

Answer key

Count your points and write your score on page 1!

0 · Warm-up & predict

Guess: c – only about 10–20% of laughs came after anything like a joke. · Predict: **banana** 🍌 isn't in the episode.

1 · Key words · 2 · The big idea

1 b · 2 g · 3 c · 4 i · 5 j · 6 d · 7 e · 8 f · 9 a · 10 h
Big idea: b (2 points)

3 · Know it or hear it?

1 b · 2 a · 3 b · 4 a · 5 c · 6 a · 7 b · 8 c · 9 b · 10 c

4 · True or false?

1 T · 2 F (at the end of a phrase, like punctuation) · 3 T · 4 T · 5 F (with other people) · 6 F (he was the friendliest waiter ever)

5 · Laughter by numbers

1 b · 2 e · 3 a · 4 d · 5 c

6 · Funny mix-ups

1 chicken · 2 hungry · 3 dessert · 4 pen

7 · "You had to be there!"

1 cheerful · 2 duck · 3 way · 4 face · 5 giggling · 6 stitches · 7 cracking · 8 there · A "You had to be there." · B "burst out laughing"

8 · The laugh-o-meter

🤭 QUIET: a, d · 😆 SUDDEN & LOUD: c, f · 🤣 CAN'T STOP: b, e

9 · Sincere or sarcastic?

1 sarcastic · 2 sincere · 3 sarcastic · 4 sarcastic · 5 sincere · 6 sincere

10 · fun · funny · at · with

1 fun · 2 funny · 3 funny · 4 fun · 5 at · 6 with

11 · Say it better (2 points each)

1 Are you joking? / You're kidding! · 2 I nearly died laughing. / I was in stitches. · 3 I didn't get it. · 4 It was absolutely hilarious. / I couldn't stop laughing. · 5 You're kidding! / Are you pulling my leg?

12 · Word search (1 point per word)

1 contagious · 2 hilarious · 3 stitches · 4 chuckle · 5 sarcasm · 6 giggle · 7 sitcom · 8 pigeon · 9 poison · 10 ringtone · 11 duck
Secret: You don't need to be a comedian. You just need to be there.



13 · The pigeon story · 14 · Your turn

1 🤫 quiet class · 2 🪟 window · 3 🐦 pigeon · 4 💬 present perfect · 5 😂 laughter · 6 💌 the card
Think about it: laughing together made them a group – they stayed to chat and had coffee together.
14: your own answers – 2 points per good sentence.

Your score

90–100 🏆 **Comedy star!** · 70–89 🤣 **In stitches** · 50–69 😆 **Cracking up** · 0–49 🤭 **Giggling – listen again!**

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